

SANS SERIF RAVI SHANKAR

Grand Dictator R.I.P.



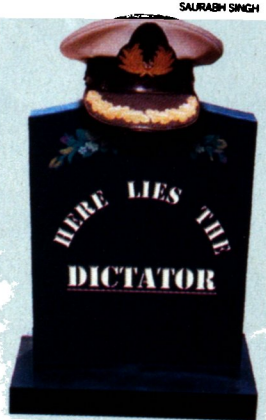
There is no glamour to evil anymore. Some sneaky, illiterate doctrine-infested coward who sets off explosives in middle class markets is today's fear object. A bunch of milquetoasts taking instructions from recreant murderers hiding in caves blows up trains, crashes aircraft into buildings, bombs mosques and claims martyr-memberships. Sociopaths strap bombs to their chests and take innocents along with them on a ride to hell. Evil has lost its cachet.

That oft-repeated phrase, the 'banality of evil', has become really pedestrian. When Hannah Arendt used it, the terrible context belonged to the Austrian Voldemort of the 20th century who perpetrated horrors that changed the civilised world forever.

But today, after Saddam fell, along with him ended the last of grand dictatorships. Mad Kim's nukes have been castrated for the time being. Gaddafi has lost his revolutionary hauteur. Castro looks like someone's uncle in *Hello* magazine. But when a Pakistani like Mohsin Hamid, whose career and literary reputation has been fattened by the West, justifies 9/11, it's ironic that evil's representative is George Bush, a President known more for the faux pax he makes than for blood sacrifices conducted during full moon nights.

The days of the Great Dictator are over. He was a modern day pharaoh, whose dark burlesque of evil was raised by the rabble, raising the rabble, and sublimating both. Josef Stalin competed with Hitler in pogroms, Idi Amin ate his victims and kept their heads in frigidaires. Mao Zedong annihilated millions during the 'Cultural Revolution' and erased China's past. Brezhnev invaded Afghanistan with impunity, fathering the mujahideen. Ayatollah Khomeini destroyed the aesthetic legacy of Persia in one fell sweep of his black robe and made Rushdie a hero with a fatwa. Pinochet, Batista, Marcos, Papa Doc, Slobodan Milosevic and Mugabe were all dictators in the old tradition, capable of grand gestures of cruelty, like mass murder and shoe collections. Drama was their staple ethos. Most began their careers as revolutionaries, who came to power fighting for the freedom of the oppressed whom, inevitably, they would later suppress.

But the faceless terrorists who exhort groupies to violence leave their bloodied signatures everywhere like anonymous scribbles. The guerrilla's doomed romance with history is over. His lethal legacy lies in mass burials and shallow graves. All that's left is an empire of dirt.



SALURABH SINGH

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"No rice, no ghee, no sugar, no bread"

BOLLYWOOD SINGER ADNAN SAMI SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about his weight loss, his music and his plans

Q. You have lost a lot of weight.

A. Yes, I'm surprised that I have. It was difficult but my nutritionist in the US guided me and asked me to change my lifestyle. There is a lot of confusion about dieting. She asked me to change my lifestyle and advised me to go on a fat-free, high-protein diet. I was very fond of non-vegetarian food earlier, but now I eat only salads, *daal* and popcorn. No rice, ghee, sugar or bread.

Q. How long did it take you to lose weight?

A. The first one-and-a-half months were very difficult. I started last July. I weighed 213 kg and I lost 40 kg in three months.

Q. How did you learn to sing?

A. I learnt to play the piano when I was five. Then I listened to Ustad Amjad Ali Khan. My father inspired me to listen to Indian classical music. I loved *Raga Durga*. I wanted to learn how to play the sitar or sarod, but my father advised me to play the raga on the piano. Then I found out that the santoor and the piano belong to the same family. I was also very impressed by Pandit Shiv Kumar Sharma. I tried to fuse the santoor with the piano.

Q. You have your own singing style. Is it inspired by Sufi music?

A. My base is classical music. I learnt a lot from Pandit Shiv Kumar Sharma. The scale of music is different in *Bheegi bheegi raton main*, which I composed during the monsoon.

Q. You also sing pop songs.

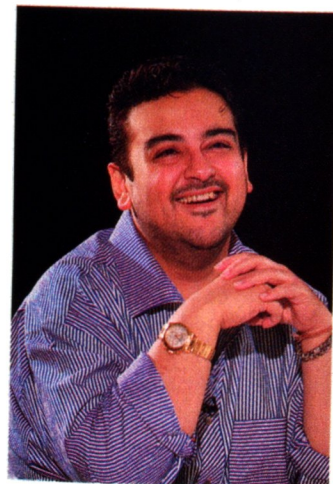
A. Yes. *Lift kara de* was a pop song.

Q. Bollywood actresses used to feature in your videos earlier, but not any more. Why?

A. Rani Mukherjee and Diya Mirza were very generous to me. Yana Gupta stars in my new album *Kisi Din*. Sometimes you see new faces in my videos if the scenes demand a fresh face.

Q. Most of today's singers are good looking and they want to become actors.

A. I'm not planning to act in movies. I'm focused on singing and composing. But one should never say never. I am very happy with my life.



MANDAR DEODHAR

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>